declaration that Ayodhya would become a ‘vaishwik nagri’ (global city), and with the plans for an airport that would have air-routes to South Korea, Fiji, Japan, Nepal and Thailand.[12] You do not have to agree with his formulation to see its ambition.

The political strategy of using religious spectacles is also underpinned by the economic logic of religious tourism. Agra’s Taj Mahal has long been the global face of Indian tourism. Yet, UP government officials have asserted that, while Agra consistently gets the highest number of foreign tourist arrivals in the state each year (over 2 million foreigners and 83.5 million Indians in 2019), the religious sites of Prayagraj[13] (289.1 million because of the Kumbh that year), Ayodhya (over 30 million), Govardhan (16.9 million) and Vrindavan (16 million) consistently receive a substantially higher number of travellers, mostly domestic pilgrims. In fact, Prayagraj, with its confluence of rivers considered holy by Hindus, continues to be the most popular city in UP for domestic tourists. Even in non-Kumbh Mela years, it draws a substantial number of tourists: 49.4 million in 2018, for instance. This is true of Ayodhya as well.[14]

This is why Yogi Adityanath, in his maiden state budget as chief minister, pushed to allocate ₹1,240 crore towards developing the Ram, Krishna and Buddha tourism circuits in the state. In 2019-20, his government allocated significant funds to this project—over ₹300 crore to Ayodhya, over ₹125 crore to UP Brij Tirtha (tourism for the Mathura–Vrindavan circuit) and over ₹200 crore for roads leading up to the Kashi Vishwanath temple in Varanasi.[15] Tourism numbers also underlay the Central government’s 2021 plans to connect Delhi and Ayodhya via a high-speed bullet train (to run on high-speed rail corridors, which are, of course, Modi’s signature project, started with the Japanese government’s technical and financial support). Also on the anvil is connectivity for the religious sites of Mathura and Prayagraj, as well as Agra, on the proposed Delhi–Varanasi bullet train route.[16]

Where China uses Mandarin and a host of cultural tools for its soft power projection,[17] the BJP seeks to deploy the cultural power of Hinduism for India’s global branding. A good example of this is the Modi regime’s celebration of yoga, which is personally fronted by the